

THE MIGRANT'S VOICE AT A GLANCE

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National Consultation on 'Irregular Migration to Malaysia'

The National Alliance for Migrants' Rights, Bangladesh (NAMR, B) organised a national consultation on Irregular Migration to Malaysia on 4 June 2015. A workshop followed the consultation to finalise the effective solutions.

Representatives from various government and non-governmental organisations, journalists, recruiting agencies, NGOs, victims of trafficking and their family members and other

stakeholders were present at the consultation. Mr Asif Saleh, Senior Director of Strategy, Communication and Empowerment at BRAC, moderated the consultation.

The keynote presentation was given jointly by Mr Hassan Imam, Programme Head, Migration Programme BRAC, and Ms Sarwat Binte Islam, Programme Manager-Rights at the Manusher Jonno Foundation (MJF). Their presentation outlined the current situation of

irregular migration to Malaysia. Ms Stina Ljungdell, Country Representative, UNHCR; Ms Shaheen Anam, Executive Director, Manusher Jonno Foundation; Mr Md Mokabbir Hossain, Joint Secretary, Bangladesh Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training (BMET); Mr Syed Saiful Haque, Chairman, National Alliance for Migrants Rights, Bangladesh (NAMR, B); and Mr Mohammad Harun-or-Rashid, Regional Coordinator, CARAM Asia were present at the consultation as discussants.

Following the consultation on Irregular Migration to Malaysia, a workshop was held to formulate an action plan. The workshop was moderated by Mr Hassan Imam, Programme Head, Migration Programme, BRAC, and Mr Mohammad Harun-or-Rashid, Regional Coordinator, CARAM Asia. The consultation resulted in an action plan, which comprises a number of immediate emergency responses and preventive measures.



National Action Plan for Combating Human Trafficking 2015-17 Launched

The Bangladeshi government launched the "National Action Plan for Combating Human Trafficking 2015-17" on 30 June 2015. It is a detailed three-year national action plan designed to combat human trafficking and protect victims by raising greater awareness and taking effective preventive measures.

The US ambassador to Bangladesh Ms Marcia Bernicat, civil society organisations, and the secretaries of five ministries (home, foreign, expatriates' welfare and overseas employment, women and children, and law) were present at the ceremony. They focused on the government's combined

efforts to prevent human trafficking. They expressed their commitment to implementing the plan through cooperative action, and sought the assistance of UN agencies and the regional and international community to fight trafficking, which has recently become a threat to Bangladeshis.

National-level consultation for women migrants by BMET and NAMR,B



BMET and the National Alliance for Migrants' Rights, Bangladesh (NAMR,B) arranged a joint roundtable discussion entitled "Women Migration: Opportunities and Challenges" held on 13 April 2015 in Dhaka.

This discussion aimed to address the needs, challenges and opportunities of woman migration. Government officials, academics, journalists, lawyers, rights and development activists as well as members of national

and international organisations were present at the discussion. Mr Khandaker Md Iftekhar Haider, Secretary of Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, was the chief guest of the event. Ms Sheepa Hafiza, President, NAMR,B and Director of Gender Justice and Diversity and Migration Programme at BRAC, began the discussion by addressing the importance of women's migration and mobility.

The purpose of the consultation

was to address the needs of the migrants and come up with solutions. Panelists and guests discussed the problems that the migrants face at home and abroad. In addition to focusing on the new initiatives taken in favor of the migrants by NGOs, governments, recruiting agencies and the training centers the panelists also discussed the new opportunities available for the migrants and the legal service needs of migrants while abroad.

Training for government officials on Human rights and migration

BRAC Migration Programme and Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training (BMET) jointly organised training on Human Rights and Migrant Workers in April 2015. Government officials from District Employment and Manpower Office (DEMO) and Bureau of Manpower,

Employment and Training (BMET) participated in the training.

The training covered the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), the UN Convention 1990 on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members

of Their Families, the constitution of Bangladesh, the Overseas Employment and Migrants Act of 2013, gender legislation and other important national and international instruments for protecting migrants' rights. The training also brought about an opportunity for the government



migration officials to share their knowledge to ensure better management of safe migration at their working areas. This was a rare opportunity for the

government officials to highlight the obstacles they have to face in the course of performing their responsibilities. Mr Khandaker MdIftekhar Haider,

Secretary, Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, attended as the chief guest at the certification ceremony.

Call for nomination 'Media Award on Migration 2015' Journalist for Migrant Rights

Migration Programme, BRAC has announced a call for nominations for media awards on Migration. The award aims to recognize the significant contributions of the media professionals on migration issues. Media professionals working in the fields of print, radio, television and internet based in Bangladesh are eligible to apply. Entries must be submitted by 15 October, 2015 to Migration Programme, BRAC. The results will be published on the 10 December, 2015. The award programme will be held on the 18 December 2015.

For details please visit:
<http://migration.brac.net>



Call for Nomination

Media Award on Migration 2015
Journalist for Migrant Rights

Submit nominations by
15 October 2015

Result publication
10 December 2015

Award ceremony
18 December 2015

All entries must be migration related media works released or published between January 2015 – October, 2015.
For details please visit <http://migration.brac.net/>

Ten returnee migrants get medical assistance



BRAC's migration programme provided financial assistance (BDT 30000 per person) to 10 migrant workers on 24 May 2015 to continue their medical treatment. The migrants had returned from Middle East countries, including Lebanon, Oman, Jordan, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia. They had been

suffering from orthopaedic problems, head injuries, kidney complications, strokes, uterus problems, stomach ulcers and mental health issues.

BRAC, with the support of UN Women, provided the medical assistance under a pilot project

entitled 'Reintegration and referral services for returnee migrants'.

Mr Hassan Imam, head of BRAC's migration programme, and Ms Tapati Saha, UN Women Program Coordinator for Economic Security and Rights, handed over the medical assistance to the migrants.

Migration information service fair at district level

Migration information fairs were organised by BRAC Migration Programme in Chittagong, Faridpur and Tangail to inform migrant workers of the services available on safe migration and distribute remittances among the potential migrants, returnees and their families in May 2015.

The objectives of the fairs were to increase awareness among the migrants and their family members and to increase access to skilled labour migration and to reduce dependency on middle men. Different cultural programmes such as Kobigan, puppet shows, and popular theatre performances were organised to encourage safe migration. The District Employment and Manpower Offices, passport offices, technical training centres, the Probashi Kalyan Bank and other banks, Community Based Organisations and local NGOs participated in the fair.





University of Victoria



BRAC signs MoU with University of Victoria on Migration

Over the past few years, the Centre for Asia-Pacific Initiatives (CAPI) at the University of Victoria, Canada have formed partnerships with organisations who are working with migrants and their families. BRAC's migration programme and CAPI have signed a MoU to exchange students over the next four years. This is great news for CAPI and BRAC, as students will have international opportunities provided by the Queen Elizabeth II Diamond Jubilee Scholarship Program. As part of this initiative, the Migration Programme will receive two Canadian interns each year from 2015 to 2018, and students from Bangladesh will get opportunity to study at the University of Victoria.



National Alliance for Migrant Rights, Bangladesh Embarks on Social Media

National Alliance for Migrants' Rights Bangladesh (NAMR,B) is a dynamic national network working to protect the rights of Bangladeshi migrant workers and their families. The alliance brings together migrant activists, NGOs, civil society organisations, think tanks, academics, faith groups and government representatives to advocate for migrant rights.

NAMR, B has its own social media page which provides updates on all of its activities and insights, including contemporary migration context. The link of the social media page is as follows:

https://www.facebook.com/pages/National-Alliance-for-Migrants-Rights-Bangladesh-NAMRB/393799707436365?sk=photos_stream

80 CBOs are committed to serve migrants in grass-root

BRAC's migration programme organised an event, "Mid-term Sharing with Partners" on the 29 June 2015. 80 Community Based Organisations (CBOs) and other local NGO partners took part in the event to express their commitment to serve the migrants at the grassroots level.

Mr Md Abir Hossain, World Bank, Ms Sheepa Hafiza, Director, Gender Justice and Diversity Migration Programme, BRAC, Mr Hassan Imam, Programme Head, Migration Programme, BRAC, and Ms Marina Sultana, Programme Manager, Migration Programme, BRAC were present at the event.

An open discussion followed where the partners gave useful suggestions to help improve the

project interventions. Mr Md Abir Hossain concluded the event by saying, "This partnership proves to be effective so that the people for whom we are working can live their life with dignity. This is a continuous and holistic approach."

BRAC Migration Programme has formed partnership with Community Based Organizations (CBOs) and local NGOs under the project Safe Migration for Bangladeshi workers, funded by Japan Social Development Fund (JSDF). These 80 CBO partners have been working with BRAC for a year at the community-level, disseminating safe migration information and supporting various interventions of the BRAC Migration Programme to promote safe migration.

GFMD to be held in Dhaka on 2016



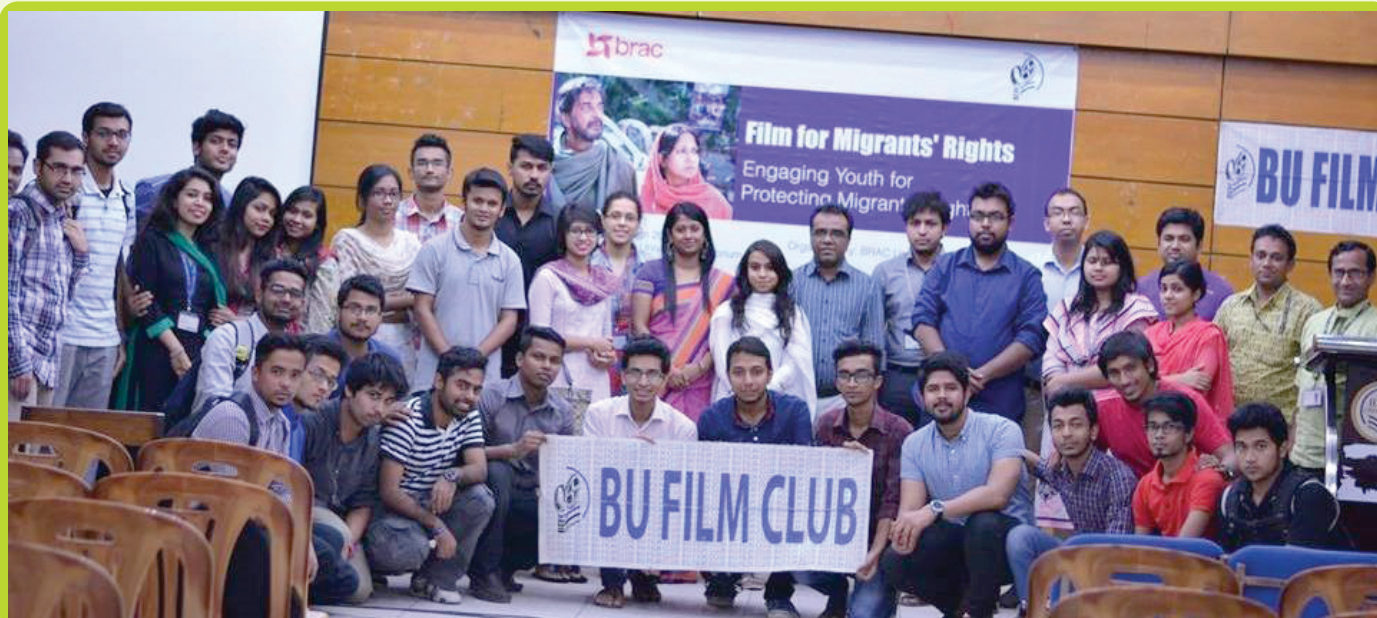
Global Forum on MIGRATION & DEVELOPMENT

The Global Forum on Migration and Development (GFMD) is an initiative of the United Nations member states. GFMD began in 2007 in order to start an international dialogue on the growing importance of the linkages between migration and development.

for the first time, Bangladesh is going to host the 9th Global Forum on Migration and Development (GFMD) in 2016. As a chair, Bangladesh will get the opportunity to

effectively pursue and further promote the rights and well beings of the migrant workers and their families. Representatives from 150 countries will participate at this global migration discourse.

Bangladesh has been actively participating in the Global Forum on Migration and Development (GFMD) since the beginning of the forum in 2007.



BRAC university film club express solidarity to protect migrant's rights

BRAC University's Film Club arranged a migration film screening in the auditorium of BRAC University on 14 March 2015. To improve current conditions and make the migrants more knowledgeable about safe migration and their protection and

rights, BRAC Migration Programme produced the film "Towards a Dream" based on a true story focused on this matter.

After the screening of the film, there was a question and answer session. Light was shed on some important topics, such as the

extent of government's help in the migration process, rehabilitation and reintegration of the migrants, and so on. Mr Hassan Imam, Programme Head of Migration Programme, BRAC, gave his concluding remarks to a full auditorium.

Demands for ensuring migrant's rights in Barisal, Sylhet and Rangpur

BRAC's migration programme held divisional workshops in Barisal, Sylhet and Rangpur during the first half of 2015. All three divisional workshops brought out many fruitful recommendations on behalf of the migrants and their families. Some of the brilliant recommendations included extending community-based pre-departure training, community based language school, direct VISA checking support from District Employment and Manpower Office (DEMO) level, linking the returnee database directly with immigration desk to ensure effective database entry, ensuring recruiting agencies accountability through monitoring per cluster and providing updated

legal recruiting agencies lists through DEMO and other offices.

More workshops at other migration-prone divisions have been scheduled as per the migration programme's plan.

Trafficked case section (will come in box/bubbles in the first page and last page with photo of the person)

1. "I did not agree with my husband's decision to go abroad illegally. Our family members were also opposing him. The middleman promised him a free journey to Thailand. So, he boarded a small boat on March 23. And after that I never got a chance to talk to him." - Nurun Nahar, wife of missing victim Ashrafur

2. "A middle-man informed me that I could go to and work in Malaysia in exchange for Tk 80,000. First I went to Myanmar from Teknaf in 2012 and spent a night there. 133 people were loaded on a boat at 8pm. The food provisions we had taken with us would last us ten days. We were told that we would reach Thailand in seven days, but on the eleventh day the middle men abandoned us in the middle of the sea. We floated on the sea for over a month without food. Around 99 of my companions died after a few weeks. Thankfully, after a month, the Sri Lankan Navy rescued us." - Shirajul Haque, Survivor of trafficking, Ukiya Upazila, Cox's Bazaar.

Migration is going to be included in SDGs

The United Nations Summit for the adoption of the Post-2015 Development Agenda will be held from 25-27 September 2015, in New York. Migration has been incorporated into one of the goals in the Post-2015 Development Agenda – Goal 8: Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive

employment and decent work for all. In article 8.8, the SDG clearly stated the importance of protecting migrant workers' rights and ensuring a secure working environment, with a special focus on women migrants. In building a perspective of inclusive growth and sustainable development, it has recognised the positive contribution of migrants to

the economies that employ them. One of the new agendas is to cooperate internationally to ensure safe, orderly and regular migration involving full respect for human rights and the humane treatment of migrants regardless of migration status, and of refugees and displaced persons.

The height of humiliation for Beauty



Beauty is from the small village of Naoga. She set off for Jordan as a housekeeper on 4 June 2015, dreaming of a new life. However, after two months, her dream had already collapsed. Beauty became malnourished because she was given insufficient food, and could not easily eat the little she was given, as it was too foreign to her. Her employer burdened her with huge amounts of work every day and tortured her physically if she failed to complete it. She was sent to the agent's office where she was tortured brutally and inhumanly by the agent. Beauty called her husband, back in Bangladesh, to rescue her as soon as possible. Her husband contacted BRAC and filed a complaint at BMET through BRAC. Beauty was finally brought back home on 7 August 2015. BMET ensured that Beauty returned with her two months' salary of 26,000 taka.

New job opportunities in Malaysia

A four-member Malaysian Delegation led by Malaysia's immigration department's Director General Datuk Mustafa Ibrahim arrived in Bangladesh on 9 August 2015 to discuss the mode of labor recruitment with high officials of the Bureau of Manpower Employment and Training. It was proposed that labour will be recruited in the future under a business-to-business (B2B) mechanism involving private recruiting agencies. Malaysia wants to recruit 500,000 Bangladeshi workers to work in factories, agriculture and households. The Malaysian delegation will be in the capital till 17 August to hold talks with officials, but no final decision will be taken with this team.

BRAC Celebrated World Day Against Trafficking in Persons

BRAC, along with other UN and civil society organizations and migrant rights bodies, observed World Day Against Trafficking in Persons on 30 July 2015 with a call for a collective effort to prevent trafficking. The event was jointly organized by the representatives of USAID Bangladesh and some other local and international organizations at the National Press Club. To highlight the issue a signature campaign was launched, there was an information booth and documentaries on victims of trafficking were screened.

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